This careful approach also aided the effort to keep the door open to China. The Indian Foreign Secretary T. N. Kaul stressed that India had to keep trying: “We have at present very little leverage with China.… Ultimately however we have to convince China that confrontation with us can harm its interests while, on the other hand, cooperation with us can be of much greater advantage than cooperation with any other power.”[252]

The US response to these Indian efforts made evident how much had changed. The prospect of Sino-India rapprochement no longer struck fear in the hearts of all officials; instead some almost sounded relieved. Noting that “India, like us, has twin problems of defense and accommodation with China,” a policy planning official, for example, noted that “regarding the latter, the removal of a source of conflict between China and India—conflict which could involve the US—[was] far more important than the effect a border settlement would have on the exact degree of Indian nonalignment.”[253]

In 1963, a shared China threat and desire to contain it laid the basis for a closer US-India military and economic partnership. By 1968, it was clear that these elements were insufficient for a sustained alignment between the two democracies. And the mutual need that had kept them engaged in the early years of this period had dissipated by the end of it.